After lunch with VP, went to E.O.B. [the White House Executive Office Building] to speak to conference on religious liberty. Prior to that we went into my German problem again. The press has the bit in their teeth and are stirring up as much trouble as they can. At the close of my speech I made a statement acknowledging that we had been confused about the Dachau suggestion—that it was part of the official itinerary and that I was going to visit the Bitburg German cemetery *and* a concentration camp.

April 19

A brief signing ceremony opened the day, then we got back to my "Dreyfus" case—the trip to a German cemetery. I told our people . . . there was no way I could back away in the face of the criticism which grows more shrill as the press continues to clamor. Mike Deaver is back and said Kohl was going to phone me. Our ambassador Arthur Burns met several hours with Kohl. Our people want me to suggest a national German war memorial as a substitute for the military cemetery. I said only if it presented no problems for Kohl. The call came while we were meeting. Helmut told me the camp would be Bergen-Belsen, not Dachau. Then he told me my remarks about the dead soldiers being victims of Nazism as the Jews in the Holocaust were, had been well received in Germany. He was emphatic that to cancel the cemetery now would be a disaster in his country and an insult to the German people. I told him I would not cancel.

While I was on the phone to Kohl, the VP was in the room with our gang hearing my end of the call. He wrote me this note:

"Mr. President, I was very proud of your stand. If I can help absorb some heat, send me into battle—It's not easy, but you are right!!